Beyond Comfort: Supporting Complete Self-Compassion in LLM-Mediated Reflection through Chance-Drawn Projective Cards

Abstract

Large language model (LLM) are increasingly used for reflection on personal struggles, but alignment training biases them toward comfort. When users disclose failure, models validate and soothe. This supports the tender component of self-compassion while suppressing the fierce component, which includes honest acknowledgment and motivation to change. Direct machine confrontation may not a remedy, as it provokes psychological reactance. This project explores how LLMs can guide reflection toward complete self-compassion: caring for the self without avoiding responsibility. We propose a context-aware LLM-guided reflection system that uses ambiguous reflection cards as mediating objects. The system draws on users' self-disclosure and self-tracking data as contextual cues to ground reflection in actual circumstances; a chance-drawn card then serves as an interpretive lens that frames reflective prompts, guiding the user to read both the tender and the fierce meaning of their situation. We further conduct a controlled study comparing card-mediated with model-asserted challenge, and a two-week deployment examining everyday use. (Inser results later).

1 Introduction

Expressing and reflecting on difficult experiences confers well-documented psychological benefits [], and this activity is rapidly migrating to LLM-based conversational systems []. Yet the medium carries a systematic distortion. Models aligned through reinforcement learning from human feedback exhibit sycophancy: a persistent tendency to agree with, validate, and comfort the user, robust across model families and difficult to override through prompting alone []. In everyday use, this bias is benign or even pleasant. In reflection on personal failure, it is consequential, as it produces a companion that can soothe but cannot honestly challenge.

Self-compassion research shows why this matters. Neff [] characterizes self-compassion as comprising both a tender mode (self-kindness, acceptance, soothing) and a fierce mode (clear-eyed acknowledgment, self-protection, and motivation to change). The two are jointly necessary. Tenderness without honesty risks indulgent avoidance, while honesty without tenderness collapses into the self-attack that compassion is meant to replace. Empirically, self-compassion increases rather than undermines accountability and improvement motivation after failure []. An LLM companion that reliably supplies only the tender mode therefore offers users an incomplete and potentially counterproductive form of support. Validation of self-narratives the model has no means to verify, and comfort where protective honesty is needed.

The naive fix that instructing the model to challenge users may fail on two grounds. Behaviorally, supportive bias resists prompting []. Psychologically, direct confrontation from an AI (e.g., "you may be avoiding responsibility") is a first-person assertion about the user that invites reactance [] and exceeds the epistemic standing of a system that knows only what the user chose to disclose.

This project pursues a different strategy. Rather than making the model more confrontational, we propose contextualized projective scaffolding as a way to facilitate compassionate candor, where we use contextual data to situate reflection, chance-drawn reflective cards to invite interpretive projection, and LLM guidance to scaffold complete self-compassion. Specifically, the system first gathers users' self-disclosure and self-tracking data as contextual cues. The LLM begins with tender grounding, helping the user identify their pain and separate the event from global self-judgment. It then introduces one randomly drawn projective card as a lens for the candor phase, where the user examines responsibility, boundary, or change. Contextual cues do not determine blame; they shape only *how* the attribution question is framed, for instance by inviting the user to weigh external constraints, uncertain causes, or controllable patterns. Finally, the LLM guides the user toward one small care, repair, or change. In this way, the card structurally mediates the hardest part of reflection, while the dialogue as a whole supports both tenderness and accountability.

Contributions

1. Artifact: (one sentence decription highlighting the novelty)

2. Empirical: (how you evaluate)

3. Conceptual: contextualized projective scaffolding

2 Related Work

2.1 Self-compassion

Read at least 30 papers about self-compassion. Especially about the tender and fierce.

2.2 LLM-mediated reflection

Start from finding papers about LLM-powered reflection. Expand to reflection in HCI.

2.3 Projective artifacts

Read papers about projective techniques that externalize reflection into an ambiguous artifact whose interpretation reveals and reorganizes the interpreter's own material.

Expand to card-based reflection.

Also mention about the card for self-compassion

2.4 Gap

Summarize a brief gap

3 System Design

Consider the following querstions

#DO NOT simly use LLM. These parts need to be VERY logical, reasonable, and rigid

1. Decide what data is needed to ground reflection (Can they really probe the contexts you need?)

2. How chatbots motivates self-closure?

3. How to combine the chatting with card picking?

4. How to design cards. (you can adapt major Arcana to compassion card, but you need to be careful. You need to know the steps for adaptation)

5. How many cards should one pick? (In intro, I wrote one. I think this can make the design clean)

6. How the system uses the data?

7. How can the chabot guide reflection? (NEED THEORY!!!)

#The above questions serve as prompt for you to consider the design. You need to be very clear and know what you are doing. You are able to clearly tell others how your system works. Your design goals, system description, implementation, the the associated rationales.